

Cover to Cover

Genesis 21 – “God Keeps His Promises”

Overview:

Genesis 21 is a chapter of **promise fulfilled, painful separations, and divine protection**. It shows God's **faithfulness to His covenant** with Abraham by giving him a son through Sarah and sets the stage for future promises through Isaac. It also highlights God's **care for the outsider**—Hagar and Ishmael—and ends with a treaty emphasizing God's presence and Abraham's growing testimony.

God has chosen this one family to work his covenant through.

Chapter Breakdown:

1. The Birth of Isaac (Genesis 21:1–7)

- **Summary:** After 25 years of waiting, Sarah gives birth to **Isaac** (Hebrew: יִצְחָק *Yitzchak*, meaning "he laughs"), fulfilling God's promise.
- **NET Commentary:** Notes the fulfillment of "*as He had promised*" (v. 1) uses the Hebrew phrase כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר (*ka'asher dibber*)—showing emphasis on **God's word being reliable**.
- **Jewish Insight (Rashi):** Emphasizes Sarah's miraculous rejuvenation and God's mercy, noting that many barren women gave birth that day (Midrash Tanchuma).
- **Hebrew Highlight:** וַיְפֹקֶד יְהוָה אֶת-סָרָה (*vayifqod Adonai et-Sarah*) — “The Lord visited Sarah” (v. 1). The verb פָּקַד (*paqad*) implies **intentionality, care, and fulfillment**.

2. Isaac Named and Circumcised (Genesis 21:3–5)

- Abraham names the child *Isaac*, as God had commanded.
- He circumcises Isaac on the 8th day, signaling obedience to the covenant (Genesis 17).
- **Messianic Connection:** Just as Isaac was miraculously born according to promise, **Jesus** is the true Son of Promise, born miraculously through a woman, fulfilling a greater covenant (Galatians 4:28).

3. Sarah's Laughter (Genesis 21:6–7)

- Sarah says, "God has brought me laughter, and everyone who hears about this will laugh with me."
- **Hebrew Play on Words:** *Yitzchak* (Isaac) is a form of צַחַק (*tsachaq*), meaning "to laugh." What began in doubt (Genesis 18:12) ends in **joyful amazement**.
- **Application:** God can turn our cynical laughter into celebratory joy when His promises come to pass.

4. The Expulsion of Hagar and Ishmael (Genesis 21:8–21)

- Sarah sees Ishmael "mocking" (*m'tzachek*, צַחֵק), and demands he and Hagar be sent away.
- **Hebrew Note:** The same root צַחַק (*tsachaq*) used for Isaac is used here for Ishmael's mocking—highlighting a contrast: **true joy vs. mockery**.
- **Jewish Commentary (Ramban):** Suggests Ishmael's actions were inappropriate and threatening to Isaac's role, justifying Sarah's concern.
- **NET Note:** God reassures Abraham that this painful act is part of His plan—"through Isaac your descendants will be named" (v. 12) is a covenantal line, not just a biological one.
- **Messianic Parallel:** Paul references this in Galatians 4:21–31, explaining that **Ishmael represents the law and slavery**, while **Isaac represents the promise and freedom**. Just as Ishmael persecuted Isaac, so those bound by the law oppose those free in Christ.

Ishmael vs. Isaac: Law vs. Grace – A Lesson in Allegory

Galatians 4:21–31 | Genesis 16 & 21

□ What Is an Allegory?

An **allegory** is a story or teaching that uses **symbolic characters and events** to communicate a **deeper spiritual or moral truth**.

Example:
In Galatians 4, Paul uses the real story of **Hagar and Sarah** to **symbolize** the difference between living under the **law**(slavery) and living under **grace** (freedom).

☐ **Two Sons, Two Covenants:**

Character/Symbol	Represents	Key Meaning
Ishmael	Born of Hagar (slave woman)	Human effort, Old Covenant, law, bondage
Isaac	Born of Sarah (free woman)	God’s promise, New Covenant, grace, freedom
Hagar	Mount Sinai / Earthly Jerusalem	The law system that brings slavery
Sarah	Heavenly Jerusalem	God’s promise that brings freedom

☐ **Key Scriptures:**

- **Genesis 21:10** – “Cast out the slave woman and her son...”
- **Galatians 4:24** – “These things are being taken **allegorically**...”
- **Galatians 4:31** – “We are not children of the slave woman, but of the free woman.”

⚖️ **Law vs. Grace: A Spiritual Contrast**

Law (Ishmael)	Grace (Isaac)
Based on works	Based on promise
Produces slavery	Produces freedom
Focused on performance	Focused on God’s provision
Can’t save or make you righteous	Brings true salvation and identity
Symbolizes the Old Covenant (Sinai)	Symbolizes the New Covenant

† Why This Matters for You:

- You don't have to earn God's love—it's a **gift**, not a paycheck.
- Living by grace means living as a **child of promise**, not performance.
- Legalism still "persecutes" grace—expect resistance when walking in freedom.
- You must **choose your spiritual mother**: Law or Grace?

□ Reflection Questions:

1. Are there areas in my life where I'm living like a child of the law instead of grace?
2. What does it mean to me that I am a "child of promise"?
3. How does this teaching help me understand the difference between religion and relationship with God?

□ Memory Verse:

"So then, brothers and sisters, we are not children of the slave woman but of the free woman."

— *Galatians 4:31 (NET)*

God Hears Ishmael's Cry

- **Key Name:** "Ishmael" = *God hears* (לִשְׁמָאֵל *shama el*)
- God opens Hagar's eyes to a well (v. 19), mirroring God's provision in our own wildernesses.
- **Application:** God's grace extends to those cast out. He still hears the cry of the afflicted.

5. Covenant at Beersheba (Genesis 21:22–34)

- Abraham and Abimelek make a treaty at **Beersheba** (בְּאֵר שָׁבַע, “Well of the Oath” or “Well of Seven”), solidifying peace.
- Abraham plants a **tamarisk tree** and calls on the name of the Lord.
- **Hebrew Name for God:** אֱלֹהֵינוּ (*El Olam*) — “The Everlasting God” (v. 33). This is a unique revelation showing **God’s unchanging, eternal nature**.

Background: Why Abraham and Abimelek Made a Treaty at Beersheba

□ Scripture Summary: Genesis 21:22–34

- Abimelek (king of Gerar) and Phicol (his army commander) approach Abraham to make a peace agreement, recognizing that **God is with Abraham** in everything he does.
- Abraham agrees but raises a complaint about a **disputed well** that Abimelek's servants had seized.
- They make a formal **covenant**.
- Abraham gives Abimelek **seven ewe lambs** to confirm that he had dug the well.
- They name the place **Beersheba** (בְּאֵר שָׁבַע), which means “**Well of the Oath**” or “**Well of Seven**.”
- Abraham plants a **tamarisk tree** and calls on **El Olam** (“The Everlasting God”).

□ What Was Going On? Historical and Political Context

1. Abimelek's Respect for Abraham

- Abimelek recognizes **divine favor** on Abraham (v. 22): “God is with you in all that you do.”
- He wants to **secure peace** with Abraham, likely out of both political caution and reverence.
- Abraham is now seen as a **significant regional figure** with divine backing.

2. Water Rights Dispute

- Abraham confronts Abimelek about a **well** that Abimelek’s servants had seized (v. 25).
- In the desert regions of the ancient Near East, **water was power**. Wells meant survival, prosperity, and influence.
- Abraham makes sure that his rights to the well are **publicly acknowledged**.

- This shows that Abraham is **not only a prophet**, but also a **landholder and negotiator**.

□ Jewish Commentary Insights

□ Rashi (Rabbi Shlomo Yitzchaki):

- Rashi explains that the dispute over the well wasn't known to Abimelek, but once it's revealed, he readily resolves it—suggesting Abimelek's sincerity.
- The **seven lambs** are symbolic: Abraham gives them as testimony that the well truly belongs to him—he is making a **“kinyan” (legal acquisition)**.

□ Ramban (Nachmanides):

- Ramban notes that this is the **first recorded treaty** Abraham makes, signifying a shift from being a wandering sojourner to a **man of influence and stability** in the land.
- The planting of the tamarisk tree (a slow-growing tree) is seen as a **sign of long-term dwelling and faith in the future**—not just survival, but legacy.

□ NET Bible Translation Notes and Commentary

✓ Note on Genesis 21:30:

- The giving of the **seven lambs** is described in Hebrew as:
כִּי אֶת שִׁבְעַת כְּבָשֹׂת תִּקַּח מִיָּדִי לְמַעַן תְּהִיָּה לִי לְעֵדָה
("Take these seven lambs from my hand so that they may serve as a witness that I dug this well.")
- The NET Bible notes emphasize that this is a **ritual of ownership**: not just words, but a visible legal act.

✓ Note on Beersheba (v. 31):

- NET highlights that **“Beersheba”** comes from a wordplay on **“sheba” (seven)** and **“shava” (oath)**—showing dual meaning:
 - A place of **oath-making** and
 - A **memorial** of the seven lambs.

† Spiritual Significance and Application

1. God Is Publicly Recognized

- Abimelek, a pagan king, **acknowledges God's favor** on Abraham—this is a key step in Abraham becoming a blessing to the nations (Genesis 12:3).

2. Conflict Resolution and Witness

- Abraham models **assertiveness and diplomacy**: he brings up a grievance respectfully, ensures accountability, and formalizes peace.

3. Covenant and Worship

- Abraham seals the deal not just with a contract, but with **worship**—he plants a tree and calls on **El Olam**, the “Everlasting God” (Genesis 21:33).
- This moment blends **political stability and spiritual grounding**.

□ Conclusion: What This Was All About

The treaty at Beersheba was about:

- **Securing peace** with powerful neighbors.
- **Establishing ownership and permanence** in the land God promised.
- **Testifying** to God's favor and presence in Abraham's life.
- **Modeling a life of covenant living**—not just with people, but with God.

Abraham wasn't just a spiritual leader—he was becoming a patriarch of legacy, land, and covenant influence.

In **Hebraic thinking**, the phrase "**to seven yourself**" (Hebrew: שָׁבַע - shava), is a **powerful idiom** meaning **to make an oath** or **to swear a solemn promise**—literally by invoking the number **seven**, which signifies **completion, covenant, and divine fulfillment**.

□ Meaning of "To Seven Yourself" in Hebraic Thought

□ Hebrew Word Root:

- The verb שָׁבַע (shava) = "to swear" or "make an oath"
- It comes from the noun שֶׁבַע (sheva) = "seven"
- So to "swear an oath" in Hebrew is **to seven oneself**, implying a complete and binding commitment.

□ Why the Number Seven?

In Hebraic understanding, **seven symbolizes**:

- **Perfection and completion** (God created the world in 7 days – Genesis 1–2)
- **Covenant and rest** (the 7th day is the Sabbath)
- **Divine fulfillment and holiness** (e.g., 7 feasts of the Lord, 7-branched menorah)

Thus, when someone “sevens themselves,” they are:

- Entering into a **sacred, unbreakable agreement**
- Making a **complete, binding promise** before God and witnesses

□ Biblical Example: Genesis 21:27–31

- Abraham gives **seven lambs** to Abimelek as a **witness** that he dug the well.
- The place is named **Beersheba** (בְּאֵר שֶׁבַע):
 - Meaning: “**Well of the Oath**” or “**Well of Seven**”
- This reflects the **ancient Semitic custom** of **making a covenant** by “**sevening**” oneself—often involving **seven acts, animals, or statements**.

† Spiritual Significance

To "seven yourself" is:

- **Not just saying words**, but making a **sacred, irrevocable promise**—backed by action and often **ritual elements**
- A sign of **serious covenant commitment**, much like how God binds Himself to His people in covenant through signs (like the rainbow or circumcision)

□ Jewish Commentary Insight:

- **Rashi** and other sages note that the number seven is **used repeatedly in covenant-making** in the Tanakh.
- Ancient Jewish tradition saw seven as the **number of divine witness** and **totality**—a promise made by "sevening oneself" is **not lightly broken**.

□ Summary Definition:

To “**seven yourself**” means to enter into a **complete, solemn, covenantal oath**, often invoking the number seven as a sign of **divine witness, finality, and sacred commitment**.

Seeing Jesus in Genesis 21:

1. Isaac as a Type of Christ:

- Both were miraculously born.
- Both were named before birth.
- Both were “*only sons*” in a covenantal sense (Genesis 22:2, John 3:16).
- Paul calls Jesus the true “Seed of the promise” (Galatians 3:16).

2. The Expulsion as Symbolic of the Old vs. New Covenant:

- Isaac (Promise) and Ishmael (Law) cannot coexist.
- Jesus fulfills the law and initiates the new covenant of grace.

3. The Well in the Wilderness:

- God opens Hagar’s eyes to a source of life.
- Jesus said He is the **Living Water** (John 4:14)—available to those cast aside.

4. Beersheba:

- A place of **oath and peace**—foreshadowing the peace we have with God through Jesus (Romans 5:1).

Key Themes for Teaching or Preaching:

1. God Always Keeps His Promises

- Even when it takes time, delay is not denial.
- Isaac's birth proves God's faithfulness.
- Application: Trust God's timing in your own life.

2. God Sees and Hears the Afflicted

- Hagar's story is one of rejection and restoration.
- Application: God doesn't ignore those who feel left behind.

3. You Can't Mix Promise and Performance

- The old covenant (Ishmael) and the new (Isaac) don't coexist.
- Application: Freedom in Christ means leaving performance-based religion behind.

4. God's Name is El Olam — the Everlasting God

- He remains the same throughout all ages.
- Application: Trust Him to be faithful across generations.

Activation/Discussion Questions:

1. What “promise” are you waiting for? How does the birth of Isaac encourage you?
2. Have you ever experienced a season where you felt like Hagar? How did God meet you?
3. What are ways we try to mix law and grace in our lives?
4. What does the name *El Olam* mean for you personally in this season?